

The best of these tools is Altova's StyleVision, which lets you display XML data in HTML, Rich Text Format and even PDF.

Click!

There's just so much to learn about XML that it's mind boggling. For lots more information and some extremely useful tutorials on anything XML, head to www.w3cschools.com—a free educational site by the W3C.

When it comes to XML editing, even Notepad is enough, but sometimes you just need a lot more features. By far, the most powerful tool for XML editing and development is Altova's XMLSpy. It's shareware, though, and we know how irritating that can be. For the freeware buff, Wattle Software's XMLWriter is a pretty powerful XML editor, too. Its interface is a little similar to XMLSpy, so it's easy to switch to after your XMLSpy trial expires.

What's up, Doc(Book)?

Now that we've looked at the basics of XML, it's time to talk about an application of XML that is increasingly making its way as a standard for documentation—DocBook.

If you were to write a book and use XML to do so, you would follow the rules set by the DocBook standard. It started out as a format for just technical documentation, but its potential isn't limited to that. As it proliferates, you need not be tied to just one platform or software—there are plenty of tools that support DocBook, including the increasingly popular OpenOffice.org.

When you make XMLs in the DocBook standard, you are creating a book that can be easily rendered into various formats - be it print or the Web. If you are an open source buff, DocBook is also a part of the open source movement, and no doubt some blessings will come your way. There's also the future to consider - if DocBook does come to be as widely used as hoped, a day will come when all the DocBook documents on your PC will be part of one massive, easily-searchable index. You might soon even be able to select a document and decide on the fly whether you want to see it as it would appear on the Web, in print, or in a PowerPoint-like presentation - a great deal better than having your stuff strewn about in different formats like it is today.

Most XML editors offer you templates for DocBook books and articles. For example, the following is a template for a DocBook article:

```
<?xml version="1.0" encoding="UTF-8"?>
<!DOCTYPE article PUBLIC "-//OASIS//DTD DocBook XML V4.2//EN"
"http://www.oasis-open.org/docbook/xml/4.2/docbookx.dtd">
<article>
  <title>Article Title</title>
  <sect1>
    <title>Section1 Title</title>
    <para>Text</para>
  </sect1>
</article>
```

Or if it's a book you are writing, your XML would look something like this:

```
<?xml version="1.0" encoding="UTF-8"?>
<!DOCTYPE book PUBLIC "-//OASIS//DTD DocBook XML V4.2//EN"
"http://www.oasis-open.org/docbook/xml/4.2/docbookx.dtd">
<book>
  <bookinfo>
    <title>Book Title</title>
    <author>
      <firstname>Author First Name</firstname>
      <surname>Author Last Name</surname>
    </author>
    <publisher>
      <publishername>Publisher Name</publishername>
    </publisher>
    <isbn>ISBN#</isbn>
    <copyright>
      <year>Copyright Year</year>
    </copyright>
  </bookinfo>
  <part>
    <title>Part Title</title>
    <chapter>
      <title>Chapter Title</title>
      <sect1>
        <title>Section1 Title</title>
        <para>Text</para>
      </sect1>
    </chapter>
  </part>
</book>
```

(Both these templates were generated in Altova's XMLSpy.)

In both templates, you'd have noticed the "**DOCTYPE**" tag. This tells whichever program that is opening the XML that it conforms to the DocBook standard—a Document Type Definition (DTD) file that enforces a structure on the XML.

For everything DocBook related, visit www.docbook.org. There's even a Wiki you can use to collaborate with other users of the DocBook standard.

Really Simple Stuff

Unless you've been in a coma these past months, you couldn't have missed the orange "RSS" button on so many sites.

Yes, the most popular way to feed content to users today is based on XML. What's more, it's shockingly easy to make one for your site too! All you have to do is stick to the RSS standard structure, and *voila!* Your own newsfeed.

Have XML, Will Use

XML is the future of the way data will be shared on the Internet. It's simple, it's small, and because it's truly platform-independent and can be edited in even the most basic of text editors, nothing really stops it from becoming ubiquitous.

Wannabe developer or just your average user, there's really no excuse for you not knowing at least the basics of XML. ☒

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